

Rs 80,000, is now within the reach of the majority of buyers.

Storage in these PCs generally consisted of a 20 GB hard disk while the Acer SX series was the only one to feature a 10 GB drive, which is pathetic by today's standards. Regarding optical storage, 13 out of 17 PCs had a CD-ROM drive while four featured a DVD drive. Interestingly, here the Dart Emerald included the fastest drive available in India, the 16x DVD drive.

The **Visualan Lavish P4** was the overall winner in this category; considering the overall choice of components and pricing, it is definitely one that takes the top honours. Users looking for hard disk-intensive applications such as databases and professional image editing will find this PC a worthy choice as it delivered very good results in SiSoft Sandra Drive benchmark with a score of 38 MBps and 36 MBps in sequential read and write tests, respectively. It also had the lowest average access time along with its sibling, the Visualan Lavish PIII. For users looking for playable gaming, in spite of featuring a Riva TNT2 graphics card, this system delivered scores of 76.9 fps and 25.3 fps, respectively, in normal and high resolution in *Quake III*—very

Upgradability and Branded PCs

There was a time when buying a branded PC meant that your upgrade options were very cumbersome, both in terms of availability and cost. To a very large extent, this has been quelled since most of the systems use off-the-shelf components and conform to standards. Therefore, components like the processor, memory, storage and video sub-system can be easily upgraded. However, there are a few systems, especially those that sport unconventionally designed cabinets, where components like the motherboard conform to slightly different standards in terms of the form factor. You would have to approach the company for getting replacements or upgrades.

Watch out for this when upgrading your branded PC:

- Find out the exact specifications of the hardware you are looking to upgrade and

ascertain whether the new hardware is compatible with the interface in your system.

■ If you are confident of upgrading your branded computer yourself, make sure that you only buy and use the hardware that is compatible with your system. Otherwise, get in touch with the store from where you purchased it and get it done professionally.

■ Also remember that any attempt at upgrading your branded PC by yourself would void any warranty that you have with the computer company. Attempt an upgrade yourself only if you are willing to forfeit this warranty and are conversant with your computer's hardware configuration.

■ Do not try and forcibly connect an upgrade to your system as this may damage your computer.

good for the casual gamer who is not looking to push the graphical limits of his system. Coming in a close second was the PCS

Oriion. This P4-based system used a TNT2 M64 graphics card and generated 76.5 and 25.1 fps in normal and high settings,

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